Coby Kassner

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Technically-oriented AI safety generalist with interest in control, science of generalization, and field-building.

Research Experience

Interpretability by design | main + extension — February–August 2025
Supervised Program for Alignment Research (SPAR)

- Designed and tested simplex-constrained MLPs towards inherently interpretable models, mentored by Ronak Mehta
- In extension of SPAR, developed a key residual-stream constraint technique that enabled stable training to low loss, after several prior simplex-constrained transformer attempts failed
- Implemented attention and feed-forward layers in centered log-ratio coordinates, with residual updates mapped back via simplex renormalization so each layer state remained a valid distribution

Inference-time privacy editing for LLMs | link — September–December 2025
Independent

- Borrowed activation editing techniques from mechanistic interpretability research and applied them to privacy, using internal interventions to suppress leaked personal information at inference time
- Reduced targeted leakage by up to 65.6% on GPT-Neo-1.3B and found a simple intervention could match a more complex one, supporting lower-cost deployment

Operations Experience

Executive Board — September 2025–Present
Yale AI Alignment (YAIA), Yale Effective Altruism (YEA)

- Conducted end-to-end operations for the largest-ever iterations of both organizations' flagship fellowship programs, leading program strategy, recruiting, and logistics
- Managed the full application processes and built a custom platform for forms and application management, with pipelines for applications and scheduling that enabled accepting 125 fellows for YEA's summer fellowship
- Rebuilt YAIA's fellowship curriculum from scratch and revamped organization-wide branding

Course Developer, Tracks Program — June 2026–August 2026
Existential Risk Laboratory at the University of Chicago (XLab)

- Building interactive, mnemonic courses for AI safety, designing materials, demos, and exercises
- Helping structure pedagogical strategy to optimize for learning outcomes

Staff Team — 2023–2024
International Research Olympiad (IRO)

- Directed program to start over 320 research clubs in secondary schools across 40 countries
- Collaborated with leadership team to coordinate over 50 student volunteers, negotiate over $15,000 in sponsorships, and organize in-person finals event in Cambridge, MA

Technical Skills

Research: LLM fine-tuning and inference (LoRA, open-weight models to 70B), mechanistic interpretability, activation steering/editing, custom transformer architectures, alignment evaluation and red-teaming, privacy techniques
Libraries: PyTorch, Transformers (HuggingFace), Transformer Lens, NumPy, Pandas
Languages: Python (6 years), C++ (3 years)

Education

Statistics and Data Science, B.S. — 2025–2029
Yale College
Coursework: Trustworthy Deep Learning, Large Language Models, Intermediate ML, Probability Theory, Theory of Statistics, Intensive Linear Algebra, Intensive Analysis, Superintelligence (Writing Seminar)

Computer Science, A.S. and Mathematics, A.S. — 2021–2025
Arapahoe Community College (concurrent enrollment)
Coursework: Linear Algebra, Multivariate Calculus, Data Structures & Algorithms, Computer Architecture

High School Diploma — 2021–2025
Colorado Early Colleges Douglas County North
Class rank: 4/209